

Africa



The world's second-largest continent was home to sophisticated medieval empires. Since the 16th century, however, it has been ravaged successively by European imperialists, the slave trade, post-colonial dictators, civil wars, AIDS, and poverty.

Morocco



A kingdom in the northwest that has been ruled over by a succession of Islamic dynasties.

500s BCE Originally inhabited by Berbers, the region along the North African coast as far as Lixus (Larache) was first colonized by the Phoenicians. By the 500s BCE their descendants, the Carthaginians, controlled most of the trading ports from Libya to Lixus and Mogador (Essaouira) in Morocco.

264–146 BCE Rome's Punic Wars against Carthage (in Tunisia) eventually result in the sacking of Carthage in 146 BCE and the extension of the Roman Empire along the entire North African coast.

429 CE Vandal tribes cross from Spain to North Africa and begin occupying the area from Tangier to Carthage.

711 Arab armies bring Islam to Morocco and establish the Idrissid kingdom, which rules from 744 to 788.

1053 Establishment of Almoravid dynasty under Yusuf Ibn Tashfin, who conquers West Africa and Morocco. By the time of his death in 1106, he also holds sway over Muslim Spain.



Battle of Alcazarquivir

At Alcazarquivir in 1578 Portugal made an ill-fated attempt to suppress resistance to Portuguese rule in Morocco. The result was a rout and the death of the Portuguese king, Sebastião I (above).

1147 The Almohads replace the Almoravids. Their Moroccan territories are captured by the Marinids in 1269.

1415 Portuguese take Ceuta, the first of many European colonies in Africa. In 1497, the Spanish take Melilla.

1666 The Alaouite dynasty is founded after Moulay Rashid seizes control of Fes from the Saadians. When he dies in 1672 disorder reigns and it is only in 1677 that his son Moulay Ismail regains control of the region. A large slave army wins back all Spanish coastal enclaves except Ceuta and Melilla.

1860 Spain acquires the port of Ifni.

1884 Spain acquires Rio de Oro (Western Sahara).

1904 France and Spain conclude a secret agreement to partition Morocco.

1906 At the Algeciras conference, France and Spain promise to respect Morocco's independence but are given the power over Moroccan customs and police.

1911 In the Agadir Incident, Germany sends a gunboat to Agadir, officially to protect German interests against French expansion. Negotiations lead to Germany recognizing France's rights in Morocco in return for ceding territory in Congo.

1912 A French protectorate is established under the Treaty of Fez after Sultan Abd ul-Hafiz uses French troops to quash rivals; Spain establishes protectorates in the north and far south of the country.

1921 Abd-el-Krim defeats the Spanish at Battle of Annual. Abd-el-Krim sets up a Berber republic in the Rif mountains and is eventually defeated by a vast French and Spanish army in 1926; a guerrilla campaign continues until 1933.

1927 Sidi Muhammad Yousif becomes Sultan Muhammad V of Morocco.

1953 Sultan Muhammad is forced to abdicate by the French because of his support for independence.

1955 Sultan Muhammad returns from exile to conclude independence deal.

1956 France recognizes Moroccan independence under Sultan Mohammed Ibn Yousif. Spain renounces control over most of its territories.



Armed uprising

Protesters brandish weapons in a demonstration against French rule on August 19, 1955, in Khenifra. Moroccan and Algerian nationalists clashed with French troops here and in 13 other strategically important towns. Over 1,000 were killed in a weekend of fighting.

1961 Hassan II succeeds his father.

1969 Spain returns Ifni to Morocco.

1975 International Court of Justice grants right of self-determination to Western Saharan people after Spain announces it will leave the colony.

1976 Morocco and Mauritania occupy and partition Western Sahara; Polisario guerrillas begin a campaign to expel them and win independence for the region.

1979 Mauritania renounces all claims to its part of Western Sahara, which is added to Morocco's territory.

1987 Defensive wall is complete around Western Sahara to keep out Polisario fighters based in Algeria.

1989 Arab Maghreb Union (AMU) creates a no-tariff zone between Morocco, Algeria, Tunisia, Libya, and Mauritania.

1991 Morocco accepts UN plan for a referendum in Western Sahara.

1992 New constitution grants majority party in parliament the right to choose the government.

1993 First general election for nine years. After parties refuse his invitation, king appoints a nonparty government.

1994 King Hassan replaces veteran prime minister Karim Lamrani with Abdellatif Filali.

1995 Islamist opposition leader Mohamed Basri returns to Morocco after 28 years of exile.

1998 Socialists enter government with Abderrahmane Youssoufi as prime minister.

1999 King Hassan dies: Mohammed VI enthroned. Liberalization announced.

2000–01 UN plan for Western Sahara founders; UN proposes a 10-year trial period as part of Morocco.

2002 Confrontation with Spain over control of a rocky islet off the north coast.

2003 Militant Islamic group explode a massive bomb in Casablanca.

«158–59 Diffusion of Knowledge
«174–77 The Ascent of Islam

Algeria



Africa's second-largest country has suffered a turbulent post-colonial history.

40 CE Ptolemy, king of Mauretania, is murdered on the orders of Roman emperor Caligula; the kingdom is split into two Roman provinces that become a major source of grain for the empire.

429 CE The Vandals invade and end Roman rule.

683 Arab invasions bring Islam to Algeria.

944 Foundation of Algiers.

1516 Barbarossa, or Khair-ed-din the "red beard," a Barbary pirate, captures Algiers for the Ottoman Empire.

1830 French troops invade, bringing Ottoman rule to an end, although opposition from the Berbers, led by Abd al-Kadir, is fierce and the region is not fully subjugated until 1847.

1881 The three "departments" of Algiers, Oran, and Constantine are incorporated as part of metropolitan France, although from 1900 a governor-general rules with greater local autonomy.